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Institutional Policies on Artificial Intelligence in Higher Education: Frameworks and Best Practices for Faculty

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ABSTRACT

This article explores institutional policies on artificial intelligence (AI) in higher education. As AI tools become increasingly utilized in academia—from research and teaching to assessment and student support—institutions face growing pressure to establish clear, ethical, and practical guidelines to help guide faculty. We examine existing institutional responses to AI adoption, identify common policies, and highlight the growing pressure that exists between innovation, academic integrity, and equitable access. Drawing on three institutional examples and current policy models, an approach to developing faculty-focused AI policies that promotes transparency, safeguards academic standards, and fosters responsible AI use is proposed. Recommendations are made for policy development that align with institutional missions, faculty autonomy, and the evolving landscape of higher education.

1 | Introduction

Artificial intelligence (AI) refers to the application of technologies such as machine learning and generative AI, including tools that analyze data, generate content, personalize learning, and automate tasks. These tools can be used to improve educational processes and outcomes in postsecondary institutions. AI can help support decision-making for faculty, students, and administrators. Its use has expanded dramatically in recent years, driven by advances in generative AI, big data analytics, and the need for more scalable and efficient educational tools that can support university systems, faculty, and students (Crompton and Burke 2023; Shata and Hartley 2025).

However, the rapid integration of AI into higher education has introduced not only unprecedented opportunities but also complex challenges for academic institutions (Crompton and Burke 2023; Denecke et al. 2023; Jafari and Keykha 2024; Kuleto et al. 2021; McDonald et al. 2024). From generative tools that assist with

content creation to AI-driven systems that support personalized learning and administrative tasks, the scope of AI's influence across teaching, research, and student services continues to expand (Li et al. 2025). But as these technologies evolve, so too does the need for comprehensive institutional policies that ensure their use aligns with academic values, safeguards educational integrity, and promotes equitable access for all members of the university community (Jin et al. 2024).

Faculty stand at the forefront of this transformation. They are both the primary adopters of AI in teaching and research, and the stewards of academic standards and student engagement (Li et al. 2025). Yet, institutional guidance on how AI should be responsibly integrated into higher education remains inconsistent. Policies—where they exist—vary widely in scope, enforceability, and faculty involvement, leaving many educators uncertain about what is permissible, encouraged, or restricted (Azevedo et al. 2024). In this context, institutions face a growing imperative: to craft AI policies that not only respond to emerging

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risks but also empower faculty with clarity, support, and flexibility (Chan 2023).

In this article, we explore what policies universities are currently developing to guide faculty, including policy considerations and key guidelines, offer three institutional examples of faculty guidelines on AI, and discuss what support faculty need to implement and comply with AI policies. Finally, we offer recommendations for policy development in an evolving AI landscape.

1.1 | AI Usage Disclosure Statement

During the preparation of this manuscript, we utilized AI for brainstorming and refining language. We employed these tools in a supportive role, and all final content, interpretations, and conclusions presented herein are the sole responsibility of the authors. We carefully reviewed and edited any AI-generated content to ensure accuracy, originality, and adherence to academic standards. We confirm that no AI tools were used to generate original research data or figures. The authors affirm that they are accountable for the integrity of the work and the content of the publication.

2 | Institutional Responses to AI Adoption

The rise of AI in higher education has created both opportunities and challenges. AI tools like large language models and predictive analytics systems are being integrated into teaching, learning, research, and administration (An et al. 2025; McDonald et al. 2024). These developments offer institutions the chance to improve operational efficiency and enhance pedagogical innovation. However, they also raise complex questions regarding ethical use, equity, transparency, and institutional liability (Barnes 2025; Dahlgren 2025). As these technologies grow more sophisticated and accessible, institutions are under increasing pressure to provide structured guidance that supports faculty and protects institutional interests (Jin et al. 2024; Li et al. 2025).

Accordingly, universities have begun to issue policies specifically targeting the instructional use of generative AI. An et al. (2025) found that 94% of the top 50 US universities had developed faculty-facing generative AI (GenAI) guidelines, with an emphasis on encouraging instructors to establish clear policies for their courses. However, these guidelines vary widely in content and enforcement, leaving faculty with inconsistent expectations (Azevedo et al. 2024; McDonald et al. 2024). Many instructors are required to navigate these policies independently, often without institutional support, professional development, or cross-departmental alignment (Chan 2023). This can lead to confusion among faculty and students alike, raising the risk of policy violations or unintentional academic misconduct (Jin et al. 2024). These challenges underscore the need for comprehensive and faculty-inclusive frameworks that bridge the gap between innovation and compliance (Li et al. 2025).

At the administrative level, institutions are beginning to recognize the broader implications of AI use, particularly as it relates to risk management and ethical governance. Dahlgren (2025) argues for the adoption of trust-based frameworks that incorporate key

principles like fairness, human oversight, privacy, and accountability. These principles are echoed in external regulatory models, including the National Institute of Standards and Technology (NIST) AI Risk Management Framework and the European Union AI Act (EDUCAUSE 2024; Li et al. 2025). Institutions are increasingly aware that the reputational and legal risks associated with algorithmic bias, inaccurate AI outputs, and opaque decision-making demand proactive policy responses (Barnes 2025; Jin et al. 2024). Establishing robust governance mechanisms can help ensure that AI deployment aligns with institutional missions and public accountability standards (McDonald et al. 2024).

Supporting these governance needs, EDUCAUSE (2024) has proposed an action plan for AI policy development that includes establishing formal oversight structures, conducting audits of AI use across campus, and hiring specialized staff to lead institutional AI efforts. These recommendations highlight the importance of aligning AI policy with campus-wide strategic planning. Li et al. (2025) similarly advocate for cross-functional and context-sensitive frameworks that account for regional, disciplinary, and institutional diversity. Ensuring equitable access to AI tools and resources is also a core concern, as institutions risk exacerbating digital divides if AI integration is unevenly implemented (Barnes 2025; Chan 2023). Without deliberate planning, innovation may unintentionally reproduce or intensify existing inequities.

Finally, the application of AI in student services—particularly predictive analytics—raises questions about surveillance, consent, and fairness. Barnes (2025) warns that predictive profiling and algorithmic decision-making may undermine student trust and widen achievement gaps. Jin et al. (2024) note that many institutional policies overlook these downstream risks, focusing instead on instructional use. To avoid these pitfalls, institutions must integrate ethical, legal, and pedagogical considerations into their AI strategies and prioritize inclusive and transparent policy development (EDUCAUSE 2024; McDonald et al. 2024).

3 | Key Policy Considerations and Common Guidelines

Policies on AI should begin with a foundational commitment to academic integrity, transparency, and equity. These policies must outline acceptable uses of AI in teaching, learning, assessment, research, and student services, while ensuring that AI tools do not compromise pedagogical goals or amplify existing inequities (Azevedo et al. 2024). For instance, guidelines should clarify when and how AI-generated content can be used by students and faculty, what constitutes academic dishonesty involving AI, and how to incorporate AI literacy into curricula. Moreover, policies must include provisions to train faculty and staff on the responsible use of AI and to support students in understanding both the capabilities and limitations of these tools. In this section, we discuss key policy considerations for faculty use of AI, including academic integrity, data privacy, equity and access, transparency, and pedagogical considerations related to faculty autonomy.

The first key policy consideration is the issue of academic integrity. Faculty must ensure that use of AI does not compromise

fairness, originality, or student learning experiences (Chan 2023; Khatri and Karki 2023). This is particularly critical as faculty consider AI use in grading and content creation, and when it might cross ethical boundaries—such as generating feedback without adequate review or using AI-generated materials without attribution. Many institutions are recommending that faculty disclose when and how AI is used in course design or instruction to students to establish trust and remain accountable to students and other stakeholders (Wang et al. 2024).

Another central consideration for policy development is data privacy and security. When using AI tools—especially those that involve student data—faculty must comply with the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA) and institutional data policies. Inputting identifiable or sensitive student information into third-party AI systems may expose the faculty's institution to legal and ethical risks as it violates sharing student information unless approved by the institution. As a result, guidelines need to encourage faculty to use institution-approved tools (when and where appropriate), avoid uploading student work to AI platforms, and stay informed about the data-sharing practices embedded in these technologies.

Equity and access also play a significant role in shaping AI policies (Judijanto et al. 2025). Faculty should consider how AI tools may inadvertently widen gaps in access to resources or disadvantage students with disabilities, language barriers, or those with less IT knowledge (Johnson and Davis 2024; Omiegebe 2024; Salhab 2025). Institutions can support inclusive AI use by providing training and infrastructure, but faculty must remain attentive to the differential impact of AI on diverse learners. As a result, policy guidelines may include the requirement that faculty offer alternatives to AI-driven tools and clearly communicate expectations regarding their use to students.

In addition, transparency and professional development are important practices for faculty in different capacities. Faculty should be encouraged to model appropriate AI use by explaining their pedagogical choices and discussing the capabilities and limitations of AI with students. Faculty can also model by discussing if/how they are using AI in their research. Developing syllabus policies that address acceptable AI use for assignments and assessments, aligned with institutional values and discipline-specific standards, is important for students and institutions. As AI continues to evolve, faculty will need to revisit implications for teaching and their scholarship, and institutions must support this with transparent and inclusive policies.

Finally, in addition to policy and ethical concerns, the integration of AI in higher education raises important pedagogical questions related to faculty autonomy and instructional agency. As these tools become more embedded in course delivery and assessments, faculty must retain control over pedagogical decisions to ensure that AI enhances rather than replaces their expertise and relational engagement with students (Duan and Zhao 2024; Pedro et al. 2019; Shin et al. 2024). The use of AI should support faculty's teaching strategies, content curation, and evaluative judgment. Faculty agency is thus critical in determining when and how tools align with disciplinary values, learning outcomes, and student needs. Therefore, institutional policies should protect academic freedom by empowering faculty to make informed

choices about AI integration, while also encouraging reflection on the implications of using generative materials. After all, many students attend college not just for transformative learning, but also for human-centered, social experiences (Astin 1999; Tinto 2012). Human-centered experiences, particularly in teaching and advising, are critical for the success and retention of students (Ramos et al. 2024; Tinto 2012). Moreover, preparing for future jobs will require learning how to work with both humans and machines (Aoun 2017).

In addition to usage guidelines, institutions must consider governance frameworks for adopting, monitoring, and evaluating their AI systems and policies, particularly at the administrative level. Frameworks should include ethical review processes for how AI tools are developed, especially those used in admissions, grading, surveillance, and even advising, where bias and opacity could lead to unintentional harm. Privacy protection, data governance, and algorithmic accountability must be central to these frameworks, with mechanisms for redress when AI harms do occur. We now look at three policy examples for faculty on AI and evaluate them based on these dimensions, and put forward considerations for adopting, monitoring, and evaluating AI systems.

4 | Policy Examples

As public pressure mounts for clear standards on algorithmic transparency, student privacy, and equitable access, institutional policy statements have become a tool for negotiating what responsible use really means. This section provides three prominent guidelines as examples—those issued by the Pennsylvania State University (PSU), the University of North Carolina (UNC), and the State University of New York (SUNY)—to consider similarities and differences. These examples all sit within large, multi-campus public systems that educate diverse student bodies and routinely influence policy conversations. They also take diverse approaches in terms of guidelines for faculty (Azevedo et al. 2024). For instance, Penn State's "Teaching with Generative AI" hub provides faculty responsibilities for AI literacy, course design, and academic integrity (Penn State 2025a). At UNC-Chapel Hill, the flagship campus of UNC, the College of Arts & Sciences mandates an AI policy on every undergraduate syllabus and offers different language that instructors can customize for their own pedagogical goals (UNC 2025a). SUNY's Cortland campus provides syllabus statements ranging from outright banned to structured, disclosed use, highlighting the system's commitment to faculty discretion (SUNY Cortland 2025).

We consider these institutional guidelines across five dimensions that recur across the literature on AI governance in higher education: (1) academic integrity, or how policies define permissible and impermissible AI-supported work; (2) data privacy, including adherence to FERPA and institutional data-sharing rules; (3) equity and access, assessing whether guidance mitigates differential impacts on marginalized learners; (4) transparency, measuring the extent to which faculty must disclose their own and students' AI use; and (5) pedagogical considerations related to faculty autonomy, that is, the degree to which instructors retain control over course design, assessment, and disciplinary norms. We also note that, given the nature of AI, we are limited to

exploring the most recent policy guidelines provided, and that these guidelines are “living documents” that will continue to evolve as the regulatory environment changes and new technologies continue to emerge.

4.1 | Penn State University (PSU)

The Penn State system has taken a supportive approach to instructors, and students, using GenAI for their work. Faculty guides and workshops emphasize having forthright and front-loaded conversations about AI in courses. Moreover, instructional designers at different teaching excellence centers are actively engaged in providing faculty consultation on AI in the classroom. This allows faculty to illustrate how GenAI can be useful as a tool, but also its subject-dependent drawbacks. Faculty are not yet required to include an AI use statement in their syllabi, but the university does provide recommended statement language ranging from general permission for GenAI use to complete prohibition (Penn State 2025b). Meaning, the onus is on each faculty member to determine their allowance for GenAI in each course.

There is also considerable responsibility placed on the faculty regarding academic integrity. The university recommends submitting academic integrity violations as a last step in a process for dealing with potential integrity issues (Penn State 2025c). Instead, faculty are encouraged to think about how to head off potential issues through assessment design and training students on how to use GenAI. When suspicions of completely AI-generated assignments occur, faculty are encouraged to have thorough discussions with students before considering a formal academic integrity filing.

The system is also aggressively pursuing both new academic programming and research around AI. AI-specific graduate and undergraduate degrees have been launched as well as an AI Hub funded by the Office of the Senior Vice President for Research and the Institute for Computational and Data Sciences. The hub has a full-time director and affiliate faculty from across the system and hosts four research centers focusing on different elements of AI. All of these demonstrate the considerable institutional resources that Penn State is investing in AI programming and research. The Hub also provides AI risk assessment for reviewing new AI technologies before they are made available across the university. Relatedly, the university is explicit about which sets of features can be used for tools like Copilot, ChatGPT, and so forth. However, the university is vague in its statements about ensuring that faculty and staff “be sure to follow applicable state and federal laws” including FERPA and HIPAA.

4.2 | University of North Carolina (UNC)

The UNC system has taken a structured approach to developing faculty-facing AI guidance. In terms of academic integrity, UNC–Chapel Hill, the flagship campus, stands out for requiring that all undergraduate course syllabi include an explicit AI use policy. Faculty are encouraged to select from sample policy statements that range from no use of AI tools to conditional or full acceptance, depending on the course context (UNC 2025b,

2025c). Violations are treated as a breach of the Honor Code, suggesting that these policies have ethical and procedural weight. However, enforcement of these policies is decentralized and based on faculty syllabi, which can leave room for inconsistency in application across classrooms, departments, and campuses within the system.

UNC offers important considerations in terms of FERPA requirements regarding data privacy. Faculty are advised not to input student information—including names, grades, or identifiable content—into public generative AI platforms (UNC Charlotte 2025d). Instead, they are directed to use institution-approved systems such as those embedded within their learning management systems (i.e., Canvas), which are better equipped to handle protected data. UNC’s guidelines for equity frame inclusivity as a central value, emphasizing the need for AI tools to be accessible and supportive of all learners, particularly those with disabilities or diverse backgrounds. Faculty learning communities (FLCs) and workshops sponsored by different UNC campuses, departments, and teaching centers have promoted open pedagogy approaches and encouraged critical examination of how AI may affect underrepresented students. For instance, in 2024–2025, there were two FLCs on (1) generative AI in teaching and learning and (2) open pedagogy and AI, looking into how AI can be better integrated in classrooms to enhance user-centered experiences.

UNC has implemented a dual responsibility model for transparency, which means faculty must disclose when they use AI to develop course content, and students must acknowledge any AI assistance they receive in completing assignments. Sample language and other tools are provided to faculty online to help communicate expectations clearly in syllabi, assignment prompts, or other correspondence. Finally, UNC’s policies uphold pedagogical autonomy. Their guidelines emphasize that instructors remain fully responsible for their course content and learning outcomes, even when AI is used as a supplemental tool. Overall, UNC’s approach offers a balanced model for faculty regarding their classroom and teaching strategies, particularly in its emphasis on integrity, faculty responsibility, and institutional alignment with privacy expectations.

4.3 | State University of New York (SUNY)

The SUNY system and New York state are aggressively pursuing AI research and simultaneously encouraging student literacy. Statewide, Empire AI—a partnership between the state, Columbia University, Cornell University, the City University of New York, New York University, Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute, SUNY, and the Flatiron Institute—allows for large-scale hardware and expertise sharing (Empire AI 2025). Within SUNY, eight campuses were awarded AI and Society departments, centers, and institutes, “to foster collaboration across disciplines to promote inclusive AI research, to address ethical concerns in the use of AI, and to advance responsible data use” (Hochul 2025, para 1). SUNY’s research centers also have AI efforts including the Artificial Intelligence Plus Institute (University at Albany 2025a), the Institute for Artificial Intelligence and Data Science (University at Buffalo 2025a), and the AI Innovation Institute (Stony Brook University 2025). There are also university and industry partnerships, such as the Center for Emerging Artificial

Intelligence Systems with IBM (University at Albany 2025b). There is guidance about using AI as a research tool, including preventing secure data from being exposed to online AI models, bias and ethical concerns, and best practices (University at Buffalo 2025b).

There are formal AI education components, and AI is considered a core competency of SUNY undergraduate degrees, with learning outcomes including, “evaluate information from a variety of sources, with an awareness of authority, validity, bias, and origin; and demonstrate an understanding of the ethical dimensions of information use, creation, and dissemination, whether from traditional sources or emerging technologies, such as artificial intelligence” (State University of New York 2025). Research centers have integrated undergraduate courses and microcredentials (Carleo-Evangelist 2025), however faculty have wide leeway to decide their own artificial intelligence policies in their courses. SUNY campuses have some suggestions about instructor and student use of AI, including sometimes even referencing policies at universities outside the system, but no system-wide rules (University at Buffalo 2025c). There are no system-wide tools to detect generative AI in student homework beyond traditional plagiarism detection.

The institutional policy review above shows the different approaches University systems are taking in their AI policies but also brings to light some challenges in terms of where responsibility lies in implementation. These examples show how universities can sometimes push out vague and continually changing guidance that leaves the bulk of the responsibility for AI use and monitoring on the shoulders of faculty.

5 | Challenges in Policy Development

Centralized resources (i.e., a single university hub website) can be helpful to faculty, but academic freedom necessarily means that it is difficult for institutions to ensure that policies are being implemented effectively and equitably in the classroom. On one hand, it is vitally important for faculty to retain academic freedom and moral agency, or responsibility and ethical capacity to make informed decisions about how AI is introduced, used, and governed in their classrooms and in their research. On the other hand, inconsistency can further exacerbate the inequities faced by students and result in blowback for institutions. Thus, there is an inherent tension for institutions, faculty, and students between pursuing innovation, upholding academic integrity, preserving academic freedom, and ensuring equitable access to higher education.

The rapidly evolving AI landscape also makes the creation of effective policies difficult. Universities, much like governments, are essentially in a defensive posture with respect to addressing AI. New technologies are emerging so quickly that affect the work of faculty, staff, and students, that universities must play catch up. That said, universities have an advantage over governments in that they are also at the forefront of emergent AI research. This gives them a potential pool of expertise to draw from in responding to this environment. Penn State’s AI Hub is a notable example of this, as its various spokes are populated by expertise drawn from within.

That said, being nimble to changes in AI and the higher education landscape, more broadly speaking, means that institutional guidance is necessarily contained in “living documents.” This can make it very difficult for faculty whose expertise lies outside of AI to keep up with changes. We have each observed cases where instead of embracing AI as tools for their own use and that of their students, faculty are throwing up their hands, banning everything, and redesigning courses to eliminate any possible use of AI (e.g., returning to handwritten examinations in Blue Books). This can certainly be a rational choice in the face of such uncertainty and lack of institutional support, but it does not recognize the needs of students and the nature of their future work (Aoun 2017).

In sum, the rapidly emergent nature of AI applications combined with differences across institutions of higher education results in policy fragmentation. This is seen in legal frameworks at the international, national, and subnational levels as well. Global bodies like the Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) and United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) issue nonbinding ethical principles and national governments enact divergent regulatory regimes like the EU AI Act or the US voluntary frameworks. States and municipalities are pursuing their own AI ordinances, often without interoperability or policy coherence. For example, despite recent threats to block state and local AI regulation, New York is aggressively creating AI regulations on everything from frontier models to use by state employees to data protections (Harris Beach Murtha PLLC 2024). This multilevel patchwork creates gaps, overlaps, and inconsistencies that challenge effective oversight and coordination. Though such fragmentation is not necessarily bad, as it can breed policy innovation and learning that can help effective policies emerge and spread across institutions (Mallinson et al. 2024; Robles and Mallinson 2024).

6 | Recommendations for Policy Development

As AI becomes more common in teaching, assessment, and academic operations, colleges and universities need to move from informal guidance to clear, forward-thinking policies. While some institutions have taken steps by releasing AI guidelines, many of these efforts are disjointed, hard to enforce, or quickly outdated (Wu et al. 2024). Faculty are often left unsure about how to use AI tools in line with institutional values, especially when policies vary between departments (Chan 2023). Without thoughtful frameworks, universities risk compromising academic integrity, widening equity gaps, and losing trust in their ability to guide responsible AI use (Temper et al. 2025). The need for inclusive and transparent governance models is urgent—not just for compliance, but for preserving the core mission of higher education.

Research from both international organizations and universities offers common principles for shaping AI policies. Chan (2023), for example, builds on the UNESCO ethical AI recommendations and broader guidance for policymakers (Miao et al. 2021) to emphasize transparency, human-centered teaching, and institutional responsibility. Together, these documents call for rights-based governance, inclusive education, and lifelong

TABLE 1 | Summary of common themes in higher education AI policy development.

Theme	Description	Key sources
Shared Governance	Faculty inclusion in policy development	Wu et al. (2024), Chan (2023), McDonald et al. (2024)
Flexibility & Adaptability	Living documents, modular frameworks	Temper et al. (2025), McDonald et al. (2024), Chan (2023)
Tiered/Risk-Based Policy	Different levels of oversight for different AI uses	Temper et al. (2025), An et al. (2025), Chan (2023)
Equity & Bias Mitigation	Inclusive access, bias awareness, fairness	Chan (2023), McDonald et al. (2024), Azevedo et al. (2024)
Faculty Training & AI Literacy	Structured support, tool comparison, ethical literacy	Chan (2023), McDonald et al. (2024), Azevedo et al. (2024)
Transparency & Disclosure	Syllabus language, attribution, research disclosure	An et al. (2025), Wu et al. (2024), McDonald et al. (2024)
Institutional Oversight	AI committees, ethics boards, governance structures	Wu et al. (2024), Chan (2023), Temper et al. (2025), Azevedo et al. (2024)
Academic Integrity & Curriculum	Use policies in teaching, authorship, plagiarism standards	An et al. (2025), McDonald et al. (2024)
Context Sensitivity	Differentiation by discipline, course level, or tool type	Wu et al. (2024), Chan (2023)
Capacity & Competence	Faculty development and institutional AI readiness	Azevedo et al. (2024)
Regulatory Alignment	Compliance with legal and ethical frameworks (e.g., FERPA, GDPR)	Azevedo et al. (2024), Temper et al. (2025)
Inter-Institutional Learning	Sharing templates, tools, and dilemmas across campuses	Azevedo et al. (2024), Robert And McCormack (2024)
Monitoring & Evaluation	Feedback loops and performance metrics for AI tool use	Azevedo et al. (2024), Wu et al. (2024)
Moral Responsibility & Deliberative Dialogue	Promoting ethical reflection and values-aligned use	Azevedo et al. (2024)

learning strategies that can be adapted to university contexts. Wu et al. (2024) document how some large research universities are crafting cross-functional, adaptable policies through living documents and role-specific guidance. Meanwhile, the HEAT-AI framework by Temper et al. (2025), inspired by the EU AI Act, promotes tiered oversight and accountability depending on the level of risk posed by AI tools. These frameworks show that universities don't need to reinvent the wheel—they can draw from shared best practices and tailor them to their own missions.

Emerging research also encourages faculty engagement not only in terms of AI adoption, but in its moral implications. These implications center on how technology can change power, responsibility, and fairness in teaching and learning. Azevedo et al. (2024) argue that AI policies must be grounded in a moral framework that promotes critical reflection, not just compliance. They recommend building deliberative spaces where faculty can collaboratively explore the ethical, equity, and social justice dimensions of AI use in the classroom and in research. This is especially important for maintaining academic freedom and resisting over-standardization in policy design.

To make these insights more actionable, Table 1 below highlights recurring policy themes from the literature. These themes offer

practical building blocks for institutions designing or refining their AI governance.

These themes reiterate that strong AI policies must balance clear standards with flexibility. Institutions should prioritize transparency, support for educators, and adaptability to different academic settings. Robert and McCormack (2024) further emphasize practical implementation steps such as forming cross-functional committees, integrating AI literacy into professional development, and aligning AI policies with institutional values. Their action plan also recommends fostering inter-institutional collaboration, incorporating student perspectives, and documenting emerging AI use cases to support adaptive governance. These recommendations enrich existing frameworks by bridging ethical principles with organizational strategy. Equally important, institutions must foster ongoing moral conversations about how AI affects teaching, learning, and the mission of education itself (Robert and McCormack 2024).

Universities in the United States, particularly those in the Big Ten, a group of large research institutions in the Midwest, are starting to create their own AI policy frameworks by tailoring international models to fit their specific needs. Many drew from UNESCO's ethical AI guidance, as explored by Chan (2023),

to ensure that their policies uphold human rights, promote fairness, and support teaching goals. This gave them a broad ethical foundation. Other institutions used the HEAT-AI model by Temper et al. (2025) to classify AI tools based on risk level and assign oversight accordingly. This kind of structure works well in settings with centralized decision-making or legal obligations to document risk.

Some universities lean on EDUCAUSE and studies like Wu et al. (2024) to build more collaborative, iterative frameworks. These efforts often include faculty feedback loops, flexible policy updates, and role-specific resources. The review by Azevedo et al. (2024) strengthens these models further by offering specific, research-backed steps for institutions. These include setting up interdisciplinary AI committees, aligning with legal mandates like FERPA and GDPR, facilitating inter-campus collaboration, and implementing regular evaluation mechanisms. In addition, they highlight the importance of providing faculty with critical AI literacy—not just technical skills but the ability to understand AI's social and ethical dimensions. They also argue that institutional AI strategies must align with each university's mission, especially in relation to diversity, equity, and inclusion.

At the course level, institutions can follow the findings of An et al. (2025) to guide the development of AI-related syllabus policies, classroom expectations, and academic integrity statements. Their analysis of the top 50 US universities reveals that while many institutions have begun issuing guidelines, there is significant variation in how clearly these are communicated to faculty and students. Most policies emphasize the responsible use of generative AI tools in coursework, with attention to originality, attribution, and learning objectives (An et al. 2025). By embedding these expectations into syllabi and teaching practices, universities are taking a key step in making institutional policies meaningful and actionable at the classroom level.

7 | Proposed Policy Considerations for AI Policy Development in Higher Education

Frameworks that align with global policy guidance, including the UNESCO roadmap by Miao et al. (2021), are helpful for policy considerations in higher education. This framework includes institutional capacity-building, ethical use of AI in education, and shared responsibility across all stakeholders. Building on these recurring themes and grounded in the work of Azevedo et al. (2024), we propose policy considerations that emphasize moral clarity, institutional alignment, and practical adaptability. These considerations are outlined below:

- **Faculty moral agency and academic freedom.** AI governance should protect and promote faculty members as moral decision-makers. Policies must avoid prescriptive mandates that limit instructional judgment. Instead, they should empower educators to make informed, ethical choices regarding the adoption, and implementation of AI in the classroom (Azevedo et al. 2024).
- **Equity-driven policy design.** Institutions must center equity and access when drafting AI policies. This means recognizing the potential for digital divides, algorithmic bias, and

cultural exclusion in the development and deployment of AI tools. Policies should ensure fair access to AI resources, promote inclusive learning environments, and regularly assess for unintended consequences (Azevedo et al. 2024; McDonald et al. 2024).

- **Institutional values alignment.** AI policies must be rooted in the institution's mission and ethical commitments. Rather than copying corporate or government approaches, universities should ask: Does this use of AI promote our mission of public service, social justice, or transformative learning? Policies must be reflective of each institution's identity and purpose (Azevedo et al. 2024).
- **Deliberative governance processes.** Faculty, students, and administrators must be regularly engaged in dialogue on the ethical and pedagogical dimensions of AI. Establishing recurring venues—such as academic senate discussions, AI ethics councils, or department-level forums—ensures governance is dynamic and grounded in real academic practice (Azevedo et al. 2024; Chan 2023).
- **Continuous capacity building.** Training and professional development on the ethical use of AI must be sustained and responsive to evolving technology. Institutions should invest in critical AI literacy that goes beyond technical skills to include reflection on power, agency, and justice (Azevedo et al. 2024; Robert and McCormack 2024).
- **Accountability and feedback loops.** Policies should not be static. Regular review processes, faculty surveys, and impact assessments will help institutions adapt their frameworks over time. Establishing clear channels for feedback ensures that policies remain relevant and effective (Wu et al. 2024; Temper et al. 2025).

8 | Conclusion

The accelerating adoption of AI in higher education demands more than incremental or reactive policy changes—it calls for an intentional, principle-based governance approach. Drawing from best practices and empirical research, the proposed framework offers a pathway grounded in faculty agency, institutional ethics, and shared responsibility (Azevedo et al. 2024; McDonald et al. 2024). Rather than replicating models from corporate or government settings, colleges and universities must embrace governance strategies that reflect their educational missions and values (Chan 2023).

As AI use explodes, academics lack a central mechanism to monitor and evaluate implementation and practice across institutions. Additionally, most policy recommendations remain largely advisory rather than prescriptive. For instance, UNC does not currently provide a vetted list of FERPA-compliant AI tools or specify technical protocols for secure data use, which can leave faculty to navigate privacy considerations with limited institutional support. Moreover, while all three example institutions encourage accountability from both faculty and students in terms of being transparent, this relies heavily on self-reporting. Across the board there is limited guidance on how faculty should verify student disclosures or what processes should be followed in cases where improper AI use is suspected but not clearly provable.

These considerations are not a fixed set of rules but a dynamic guide—flexible enough to evolve alongside AI technology and robust enough to center ethical and pedagogical integrity. Institutions that adopt this approach can better align their policies with core commitments to academic freedom, equity, and transparency (Temper et al. 2025; Wu et al. 2024). Ultimately, AI governance is not just a compliance task but a strategic opportunity to shape the future of higher education as a space of trust, learning, and human-centered innovation.

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